Tampa, South Florida and Orlando among top 5 U.S. COVID moving destinations

Business

The COVID-19 pandemic has locked many Americans in place. But some are picking up stakes — choosing Florida over almost every other destination.

According to real estate firm FCP and geospatial analytics group Orbital Insight, Tampa is the No. 1 relocation destination for Americans who have moved during COVID.

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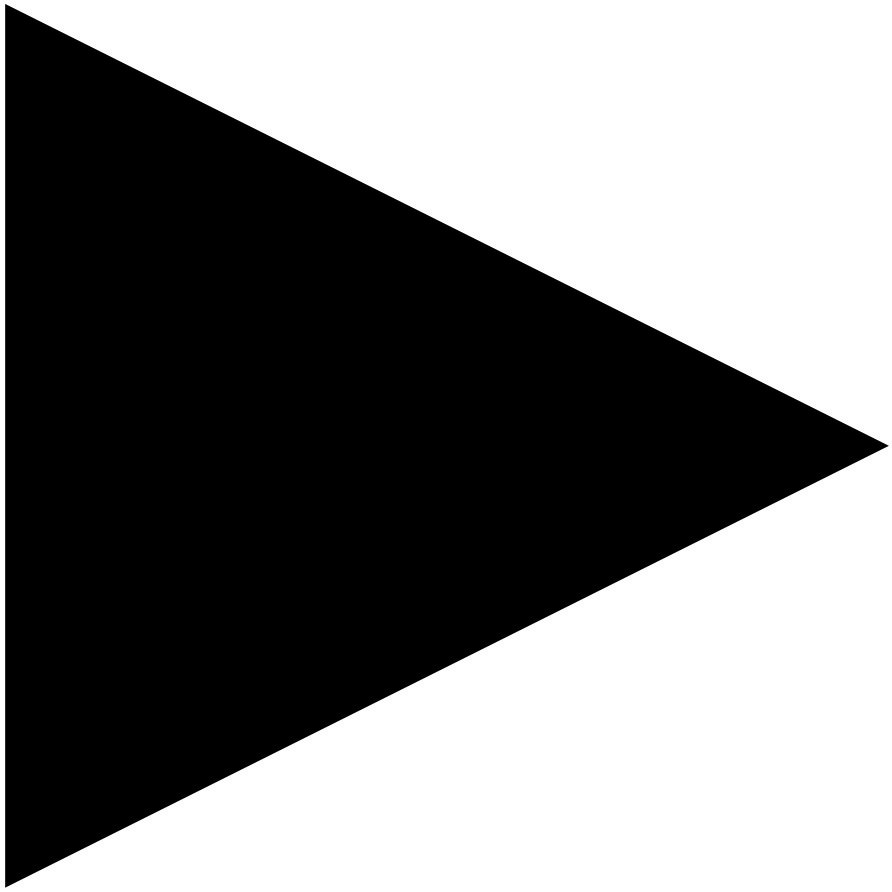

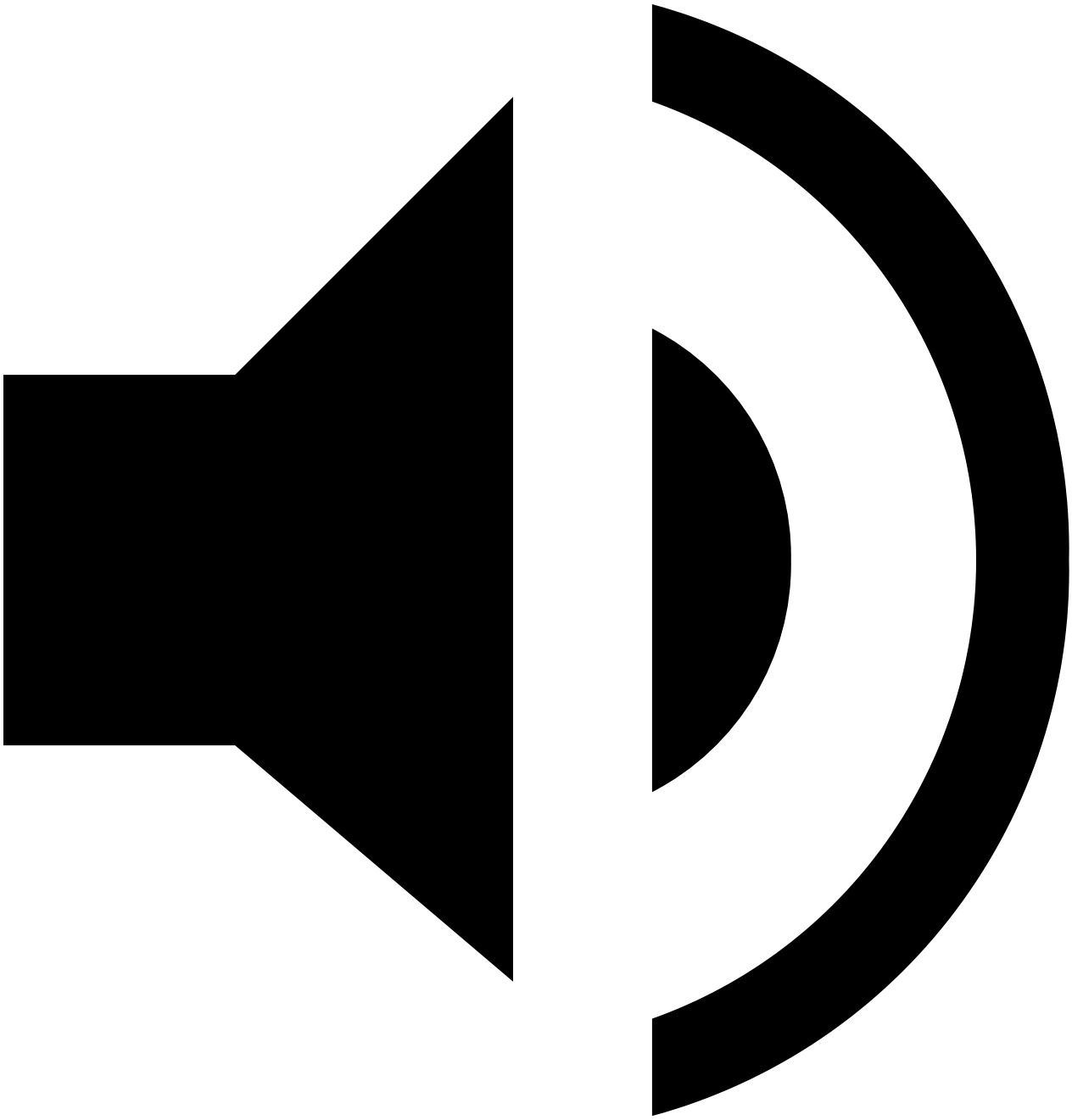

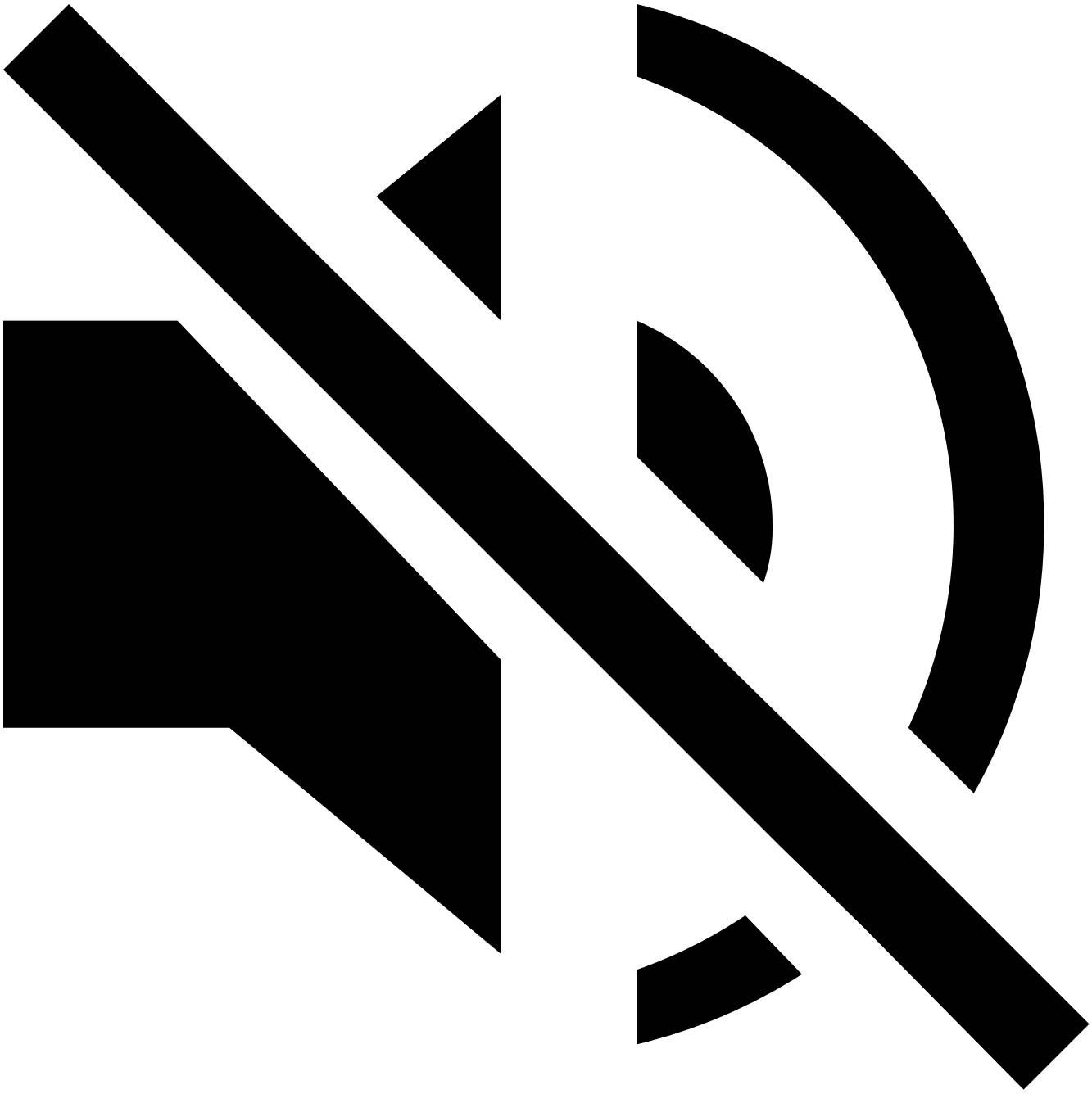

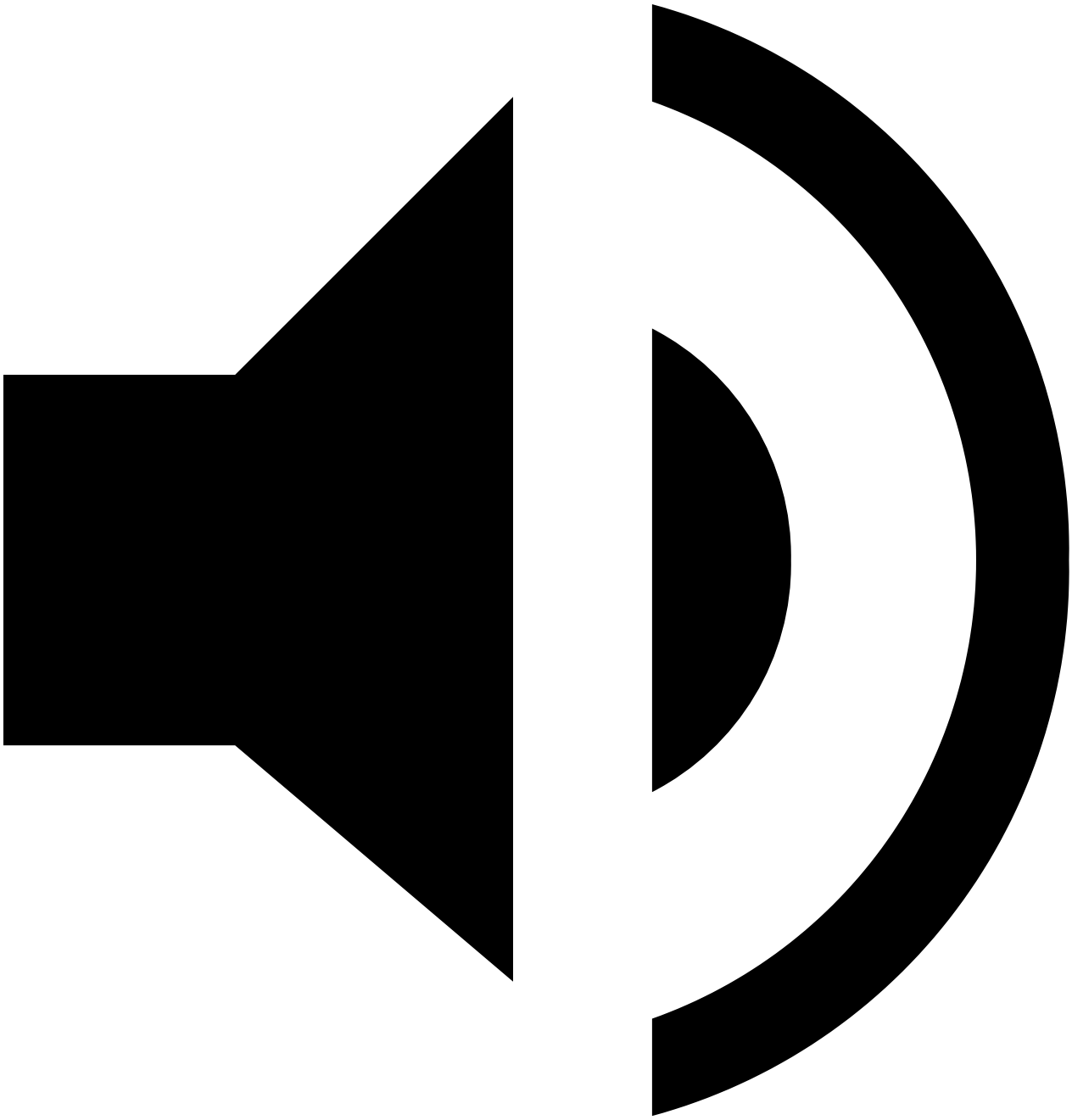

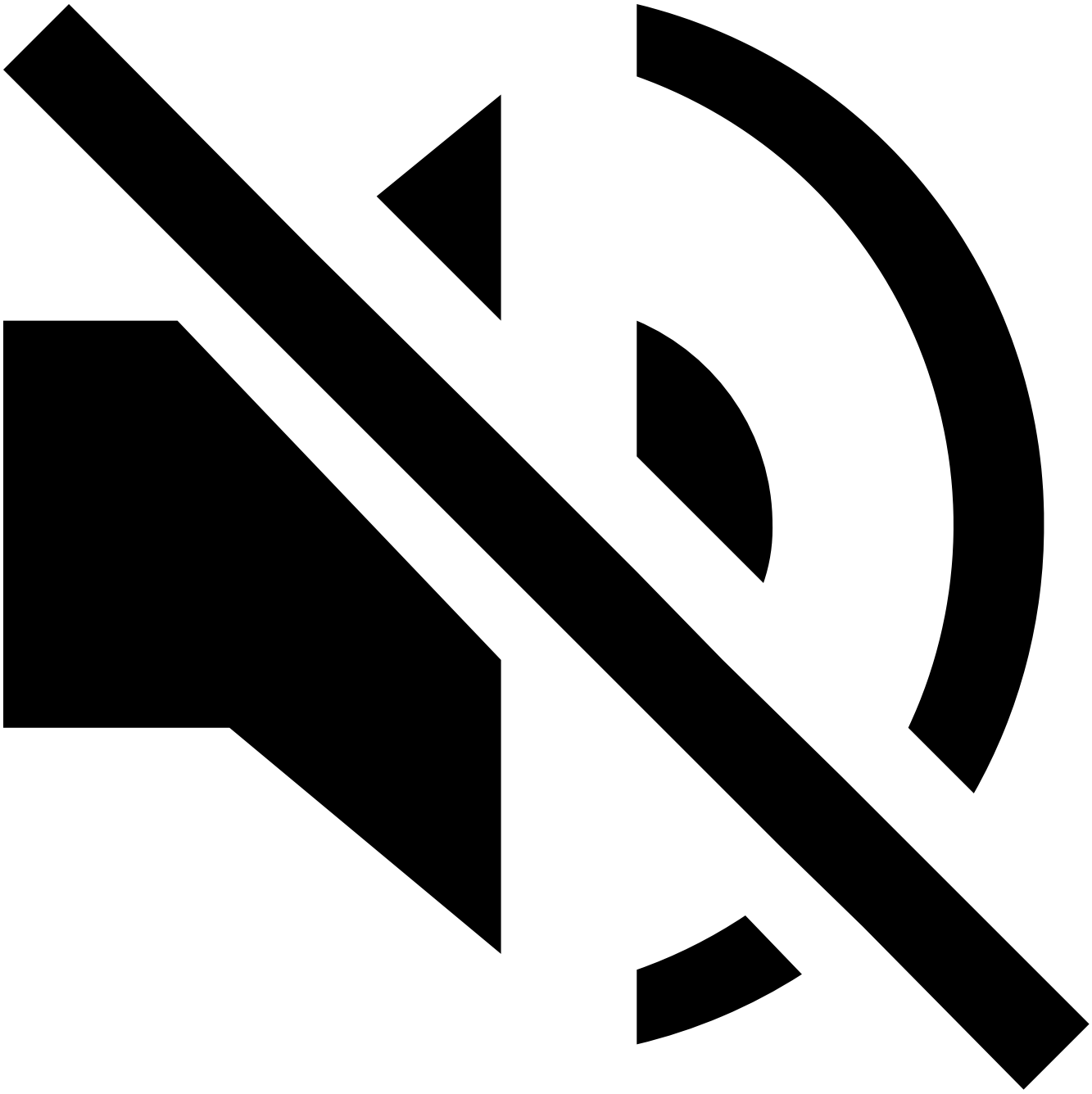

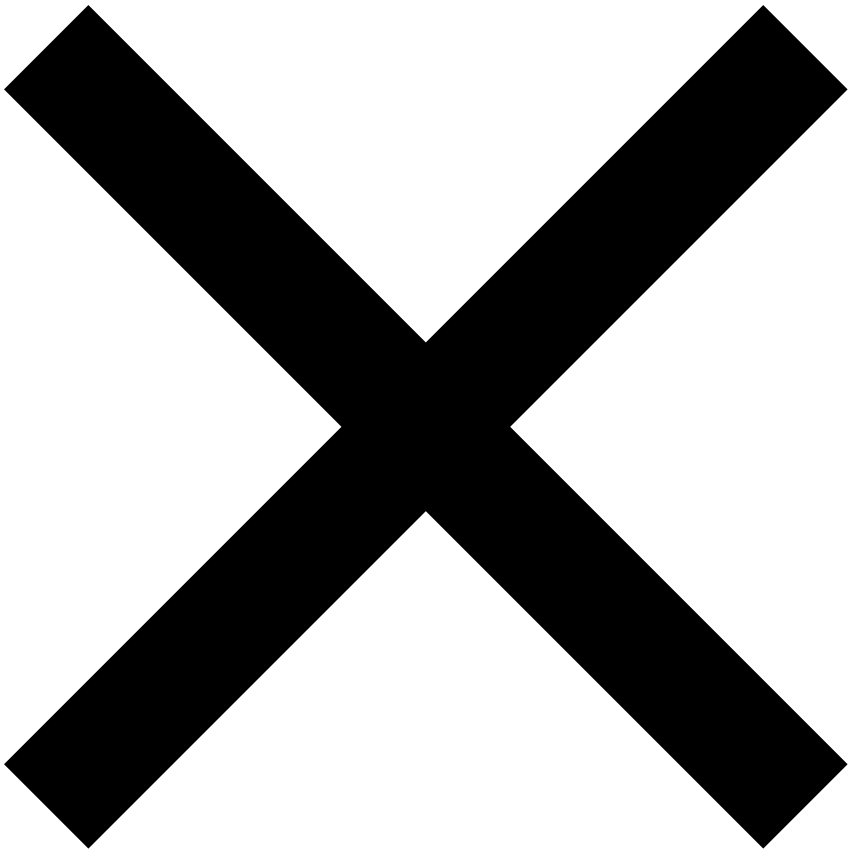

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South Florida — meaning the Miami-Fort Lauderdale-Pompano Beach area — comes in at No. 4, with Orlando at No. 5.

In between are Phoenix (No. 2) and New York City (No. 3).

Using Orbital Insight's data, FCP analyzed approximately 3.8 million cellphone numbers from major metropolitan areas. It compared the phones' 2019 locations with their locations from March through June, as well as March through September, to understand migration both during lockdown and the pandemic overall. The identities of the cellphones' users were rendered anonymous.

Because different cities contained different quantities of cellphones, FCP did not compute raw moving totals. Instead, it counted which destinations were most frequent among the metropolitan areas studied.

Tampa won out with 12 other metros marking it as a top-three moving destination. For example, residents moving out of Detroit, Louisville and Orlando all made Tampa their top destination choice.

South Florida and Orlando tied with seven top-3 finishes. South Florida was the most popular choice for residents moving out of Atlanta, while Orlando was the most popular for those moving out of Jacksonville.

The data did not capture whether more residents are moving into a metro area than moving out.

Matt Larriva, Vice President Research and Data Analytics at FCP, said the data show that the Sun Belt retains its pre-COVID status as a destination of choice, both for those relocating from elsewhere and those already in the Sun Belt.

Florida's popularity is likely due to individuals looking for a warm, outdoor-oriented destination to ward off COVID, Larriva said. Individuals also may be moving up retirement as a result of the pandemic, he said. And Florida's tax-friendly climate has always made it a popular landing spot.

Additional proof is in South Florida's red-hot real-estate market, where single-family home prices have reached their highest levels since 2007.

Larriva said FCP's and Orbital Insight's methodology is more accurate than some destination lists provided by moving companies, both because it shows real-time moves and controls for individuals who may not have moved using a moving service.

"Everyone has a cellphone," he said.

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